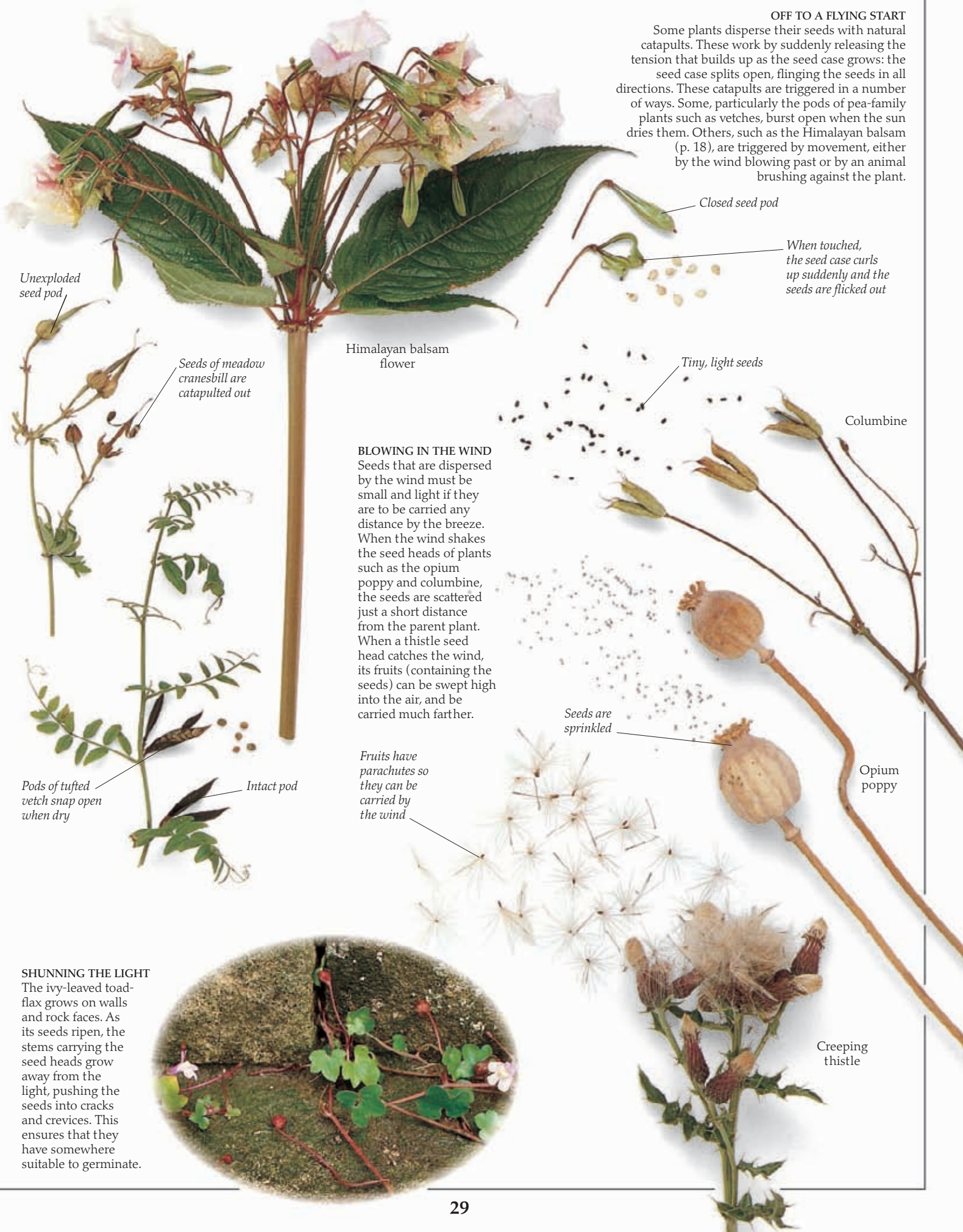


OFF TO A FLYING START

Some plants disperse their seeds with natural catapults. These work by suddenly releasing the tension that builds up as the seed case grows: the seed case splits open, flinging the seeds in all directions. These catapults are triggered in a number of ways. Some, particularly the pods of pea-family plants such as vetches, burst open when the sun dries them. Others, such as the Himalayan balsam (p. 18), are triggered by movement, either by the wind blowing past or by an animal brushing against the plant.



BLOWING IN THE WIND

Seeds that are dispersed by the wind must be small and light if they are to be carried any distance by the breeze. When the wind shakes the seed heads of plants such as the opium poppy and columbine, the seeds are scattered just a short distance from the parent plant. When a thistle seed head catches the wind, its fruits (containing the seeds) can be swept high into the air, and be carried much farther.

SHUNNING THE LIGHT

The ivy-leaved toad-flax grows on walls and rock faces. As its seeds ripen, the stems carrying the seed heads grow away from the light, pushing the seeds into cracks and crevices. This ensures that they have somewhere suitable to germinate.